

The King's Comment: Writeup

CATEGORY	OSINT	DIFFICULTY	Medium
DATE	21/09/2026	FLAG FORMAT	INFOSEC_SIG{...}

Challenge Description

"Same **royal** spot, same view across the street, same **5 star review** with a secret inside. Only problem is my review doesn't want to show up this time no matter how hard you scroll. Luckily, every good order comes with **something extra** on the side. Check what came packed with this photo and it could take you, to wherever you wish to be"



Figure 1: Challenge card

Step 1: Parse the Hints

The description gives three leads:

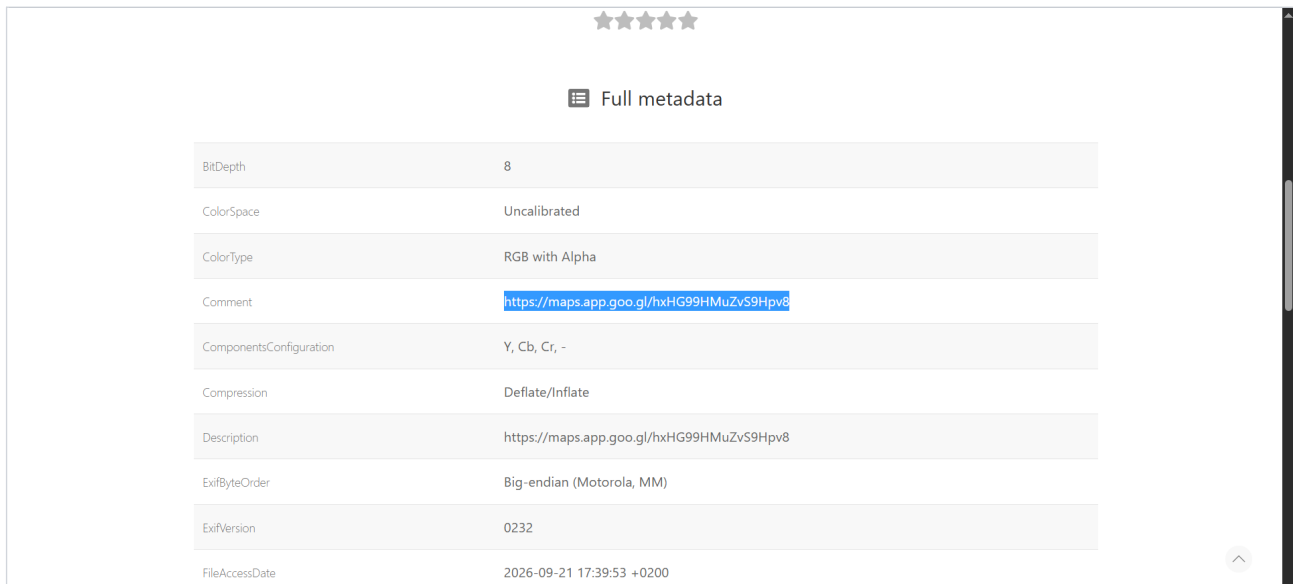
- "**royal spot**" points to a place with "King" in its name.
- "**5 star review with a secret inside**" means the flag is hidden in a review.
- "**something extra... packed with this photo**" means data is embedded in the image file.

The image could be geolocated by eye, but the correct approach is to enumerate all available data first. That means checking the metadata.

Step 2: Extract Image Metadata

Run the image through an EXIF viewer (exiftool image.png or any online metadata viewer). Both the **Comment** and **Description** fields contain a Google Maps short link:

Comment: <https://maps.app.goo.gl/hxHG99HMuZvS9Hp8>
Description: <https://maps.app.goo.gl/hxHG99HMuZvS9Hp8>



BitDepth	8
ColorSpace	Uncalibrated
ColorType	RGB with Alpha
Comment	https://maps.app.goo.gl/hxHG99HMuZvS9Hp8
ComponentsConfiguration	Y, Cb, Cr, -
Compression	Deflate/Inflate
Description	https://maps.app.goo.gl/hxHG99HMuZvS9Hp8
ExifByteOrder	Big-endian (Motorola, MM)
ExifVersion	0232
FileAccessDate	2026-09-21 17:39:53 +0200

Figure 2: Image metadata showing the Maps link in the Comment and Description fields

Step 3: Follow the Link to the Location

The link resolves to **Kings Shawarma**, a shawarma restaurant on Maulana Shaukat Ali Road in Nagpada, Mumbai. This matches the "royal spot" hint.

Google had removed the original review after flagging it as suspicious, which is what the hint about the review not showing up refers to. Sending the original link to the challenge author (Khush) in DMs gets you a corrected link:

<https://maps.app.goo.gl/kKvDJ4jfo4rwkmWu8>

Step 4: Find the Review

The corrected link shows a 5-star review by **Khush Madhwani** on Kings Shawarma:

★★★★★ *Damn, that was some good shawarma!*
secret code:

VTFVMVixUXhUa1pSTVRsVVUxVmtOMDVXT1hwa1JGSjVZekU1YlUxSVNtWk5TRTE0
wW01U1ptTXLjM2hpUjNoNlpsRTLQUT09

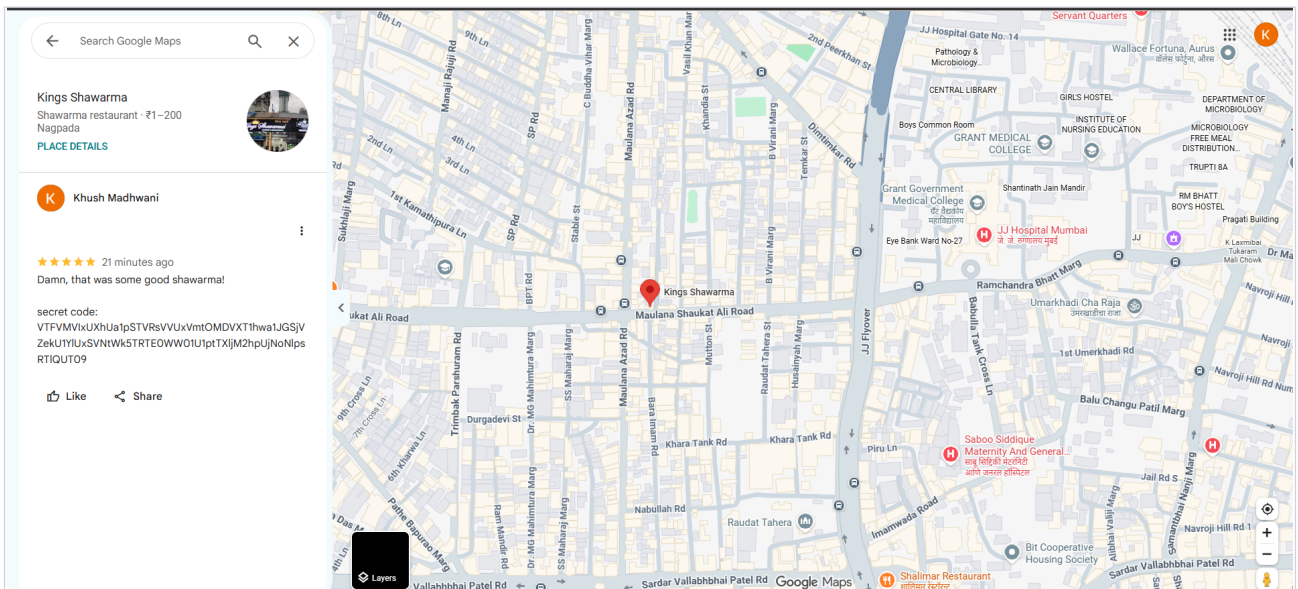


Figure 3: The 5-star review on Kings Shawarma containing the secret code

Step 5: Decode the Secret

The string is base64 encoded three times.

```
echo 'VTfVMVixUXhUa1pSTVRsVVUxVmtOMDVXT1hwa1JGSjVZekU1YlUxSVNtWk5TRTE0\WW01U1ptTXlJm2hpUjNoNlpsRTLQUT09' | base64 -d | base64 -d | base64 -d
```

The output at each layer:

```
Layer 1: U1U1R1QxTkZRMTLUU1VKn05W0XpkRFJ5YzE5bU1ISmZNSE14Ym5SZmMyc3hiR3h6ZlE9PQ==
Layer 2: SU5GT1NFQ19TSud7NV9zdDRyc19mMHJfMHMxbnRfc2sxbGxzZfQ==
Layer 3: INFOSEC_SIG{5_st4rs_f0r_0s1nt_sk1lls}
```

(CyberChef alternative: apply **From Base64** three times.)

Flag

INFOSEC_SIG{5_st4rs_f0r_0s1nt_sk1lls}